

STAGE TWO • PROFESSIONAL IDENTITY & PERSONAL BRAND

FIRSTS

GROUP VERSIONS OF KEY EXERCISES

Live, group-adapted versions of the FIRSTS that benefit most from interaction

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Group Versions of Key Exercises

Stage Two • Professional Identity & Personal Brand

PURPOSE

Stage Two's forty FIRSTS are written for solo drafting and reflection — write your introduction, audit your own reputation, build your own portfolio. But personal brand is fundamentally about how you land with other people, which makes it one of the stages that benefits most from genuinely live, social versions of its exercises. You cannot fully judge your own elevator pitch, headshot, or video introduction from the inside.

This document adapts ten FIRSTS across all six sections of Stage Two into pair, small-group, or role-play formats. As with every stage, these are additions, not replacements — participants complete their own individual work first, and the group version tests or deepens it. Ten was a deliberate choice for a forty-FIRST stage: these are the ones where outside perspective is genuinely load-bearing, not just a nice-to-have.

Each entry includes a suggested format, the extra time it adds beyond the solo version, numbered steps you can read almost verbatim to a group, and a short note on why the live version specifically matters here.

The Ten Adapted Exercises

FIRST B01

Professional Introduction — Rotating Practice Round

TIME: +15 min beyond solo drafting

1. After drafting individually, form two concentric circles (or two lines) facing each other.
2. Each pair delivers their introduction to each other, 30 seconds each, then the outer circle rotates one position.
3. Repeat for 4–5 rotations. After each one, note anything a new listener's reaction taught you.
4. Debrief: did your delivery genuinely change or improve across rotations?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Repetition in front of genuinely new listeners (not the same partner each time) reveals which parts of the introduction reliably land and which parts need reworking — far more useful than a single run-through.

FIRST B03

Personal Brand Statement — Stranger Test

TIME: +10 min beyond solo drafting

1. Pairs. Partner A reads their brand statement to Partner B exactly once.
2. Partner B, without looking at the written statement, tries to repeat back the core idea in their own words.
3. Compare: did the paraphrase capture what Partner A actually meant?

FACILITATOR NOTE

A brand statement that can't survive being paraphrased by a first-time listener is too dense or too vague. This is a fast, genuine clarity test.

FIRST B09

Professional Reputation Awareness — Outside-In Panel

TIME: +15 min beyond solo reflection

1. Groups of 4. Each person names one word they believe colleagues would use to describe their professional reputation.
2. The other three group members privately write down the word they'd actually use, without discussion, then reveal simultaneously.
3. Discuss any gap: where did self-perception and group perception diverge, and why might that be?

FACILITATOR NOTE

This works because it's simultaneous, not sequential — revealing all answers at once prevents the group from anchoring to the first word said, which produces more honest, independent

responses.

FIRST B11

Credibility Signals — Signal Spotting

TIME: +10 min beyond solo work

1. Small groups review 2–3 real (anonymized or public) LinkedIn profiles together, projected or shared on screen.
2. Each group has 90 seconds per profile to name every credibility signal they can spot — certifications, specific metrics, endorsements, tenure.
3. Compare lists across groups: what did some groups catch that others missed?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Spotting credibility signals in someone else's profile is far easier than in your own, and it directly primes what participants should look for and build into their own LinkedIn Profile (FIRST 13) next.

FIRST B19

Professional Headshot — Peer Photo Review

TIME: +15 min beyond individual photo-taking

1. Each participant brings 2–3 candidate headshot options (phone photos are fine).
2. In small groups, each person shows their options without saying which one they personally prefer.
3. Group votes on which option looks most genuinely professional and approachable, then compares to the person's own instinct.

FACILITATOR NOTE

People are often poor judges of their own best photo. A quick, kind outside vote resolves headshot indecision faster than solo deliberation.

FIRST B23

Meeting Presence — Fishbowl Role-Play

TIME: +20 min beyond framing

1. Select 4–5 volunteers to hold a short (5-minute) mock meeting on a simple prompt (e.g., “where should the team offsite be?”) in the center of the room.
2. Everyone else observes silently, each assigned one specific thing to watch for: body language, airtime balance, who asks questions, who builds on others' ideas.
3. Debrief as a full group: what specific behaviors signaled strong meeting presence?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Watching real (if low-stakes) meeting behavior is far more instructive than describing it abstractly. Rotate volunteers if time allows so more people get the observed experience.

FIRST B25

Professional Listening Skill — Paraphrase Relay

TIME: +15 min beyond solo reflection

1. Pairs. Partner A talks for 90 seconds about a genuine current work or school challenge.
2. Partner B may not respond with their own opinion — only paraphrase what they heard, then ask one genuine follow-up question.
3. Partner A confirms whether the paraphrase was accurate. Swap roles.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Banning advice-giving forces genuine listening rather than half-listening while planning a response — the exact habit this FIRST is trying to build.

FIRST B27

Video Introduction — Peer Review Circle

TIME: +15 min beyond individual recording

1. Participants record their video introduction individually beforehand or during a quiet solo block.
2. In groups of 3, each person plays their video for the group.
3. Group gives exactly two pieces of feedback: one thing that felt genuine, one thing that felt stiff or scripted.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Video is uniquely revealing — people often can't hear their own filler words or see their own stiffness until watching alongside others who react in real time.

FIRST B34

Professional Conversation Starter — Speed Networking

TIME: +15 min beyond solo prep

1. Participants prepare 2–3 genuine conversation starters relevant to the group's shared context (industry, program, event).
2. Run 3 rounds of 3-minute paired conversations, rotating partners each round, using only prepared starters to begin.
3. Debrief: which starter most reliably led to a genuine, substantive conversation rather than small talk that fizzled?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Speed rounds force participants to actually use their prepared starters rather than defaulting to generic small talk, and rapid rotation reveals which starters generalize well across different people.

FIRST B39

Online Portfolio Review — Swap & Critique

TIME: +20 min beyond solo build

1. Pairs (ideally people who don't know each other's work well). Each shares their portfolio link with the other.
2. Each person spends 5 minutes reviewing their partner's portfolio as if they were a hiring manager seeing it cold.
3. Give three pieces of feedback: what's immediately clear, what's confusing, what's missing.

FACILITATOR NOTE

A portfolio's creator is the worst-positioned person to spot what's confusing to a first-time viewer — genuine outside eyes catch this reliably.